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Love Fulfills the Law

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Love Fulfills the Law

Galatians 5:13-25; Romans 13:8-10

When I was young, my mother taped a hand-written note to the refrigerator door: “God doesn’t love us because we are good; He makes us good because He loves us.” As a teenager growing up, I thought these words were just wishful thinking. But, in my ongoing journey of learning of God’s love, I began to understand them as powerful, freeing truth. I began to comprehend that when we are connected to God and His love, we become right on the outside because we are right on the inside. God doesn’t intend for us to live the Christian life by trying to be “good” and follow rules. He designed us to live by resting in His love—with our soul surrendered to His Spirit. Jesus never asks us to live the Christian life; He asks us to let Him live His life through us.

When the Holy Spirit comes to live in our spirit by faith, we are born again and inherit eternal life. But, as Paul makes clear, there is more to life than being born again; there is also right living in this life. When we “are led by the Spirit” or “keep in step with the Spirit” (to use Paul’s words), we walk out our lives on earth led by God. In this way, our soul—not just our spirit—is in alignment with God’s plan. But until the soul bends to the leading of the Spirit, the Spirit and the flesh (the soul and body together) will be in constant conflict.

God’s love for us calls us and provides for us to be “led by the Spirit.” When we know God’s complete love for us, we can trust Him in all things and surrender our will to His. We can let our will rest in His. We serve God, not because of pressure from without (such as the law), but because of the love of Christ within. In this way, “love is the fulfillment of the law.”

In the passages for this lesson, Paul is not giving us a list of ways to act or rules to obey. Rather, he is describing what God’s love manifested through us looks like. He is giving us a description of the Christian life that comes naturally from being led by the Spirit—from being led by God who is love.

Read Galatians 5:13-25 and Romans 13:8-10.

Galatians 5:13-25

13You, my brothers and sisters, were called to be free. But do not use your freedom to indulge the flesh; rather, serve one another humbly in love. 14For the entire law is fulfilled in keeping this one command: ‘Love your neighbor as yourself.’ 15If you bite and devour each other, watch out or you will be destroyed by each other. 16So I say, live by the Spirit, and you will not gratify the desires of the flesh. 17For

the flesh desires what is contrary to the Spirit, and the Spirit what is contrary to the flesh. They are in conflict with each other, so that you are not to do whatever you want. 18But if you are led by the Spirit, you are not under the law.

19The acts of the flesh are obvious: sexual immorality, impurity and debauchery; 20 idolatry and witchcraft; hatred, discord, jealousy, fits of rage, selfish ambition, dissensions, factions 21and envy; drunkenness, orgies, and the like. I warn you, as I did before, that those who live like this will not inherit the kingdom of God.

22But the fruit of the Spirit is love, joy, peace, forbearance, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, 23gentleness and self-control. Against such things there is no law.

24Those who belong to Christ Jesus have crucified the flesh with its passions and desires. 25Since we live by the Spirit, let us keep in step with the Spirit.

Romans 13:8-10

8 Owe no one anything except to love one another, for he who loves another has fulfilled the law. 9For the commandments, “You shall not commit adultery,” “You shall not murder,” “You shall not steal,” “You shall not bear false witness,” “You shall not covet,” and if there is any other commandment, are all summed up in this saying, namely, “You shall love your neighbor as yourself.” 10Love does no harm to a neighbor; therefore love is the fulfillment of the law.

Questions

1. Galatians 5:13 says we have been “called to be free.” What are we freed from? Who are we free to become?
2. According to verse 14, the law is fulfilled in keeping the command “love your neighbor as yourself.” How do you actually come to love your neighbor as yourself?
3. As described in verse 16, how do we keep from “gratify[ing] the desires of the flesh”? In what ways do you personally try to keep from “gratify[ing] the desires of the flesh”?
4. What role, if any, does the law play in helping us avoid the desires of the flesh?
5. According to verse 17, the Spirit and the flesh are contrary to one another. What does this mean? If possible, give a personal example of how you have experienced this conflict.
6. What does it mean to you to be “led by the Spirit” (v 18)?
7. According to verses 22-23, what are the fruit of the Spirit? How do our lives come to bear such fruit?

8. How do you know when you are being led by the Spirit? How do you know when you are being led by your own “good” flesh?
9. A baby learns to walk by taking a few steps and falling and then getting up and trying again. How does this analogy apply to learning to walk in the Spirit? If possible, give a personal example.
0. Rephrase Romans 13:8–10 into your own words. How is love the fulfillment of the law?
1. In what ways do Christians often live their lives as if faith (not love) is the fulfillment of the law? In what ways might you be living your life in this way?
2. Imagine and describe the life of a person who is completely led by the Spirit—who acts, speaks and thinks only as the Spirit leads.

Reflection

Get alone in a quiet place with God.

Imagine that you are a branch growing from a strong vine. Jesus is that vine and your connection with Him supplies everything to you. As part of the vine, you are vigorous and healthy. Life giving sap flows into you causing you to bear fruit. Loving deeds and right attitudes come forth naturally as you abide in Jesus’ love.

Let yourself receive and experience His love. Rest in it. Grow in it. Live in it.

Study Notes

Jesus summed up the Old Covenant law with these words: “Love the Lord your God with all your heart with all your soul, and with all your mind ... And ... love your neighbor as yourself” (Matthew 22:37–39). The Old Covenant demanded that we love God and our neighbor. But in the New Covenant, Jesus said, “A new command I give you: Love one another. As I have loved you, so you must love one another” (John 13:34). In the New Covenant, God loves us first. Love starts with God; He is the source. First John 4:19 says, “We love because he first loved us.”

In Galatians 3:24 Paul tells us, “So the law was our guardian until Christ came that we might be justified by faith.” The purpose of the law was to point out the failure of our own self-efforts, so that we would come to trust in Jesus who alone can save us. In John 15:4 Jesus said, “Remain in me, as I also remain in you. No branch can bear fruit by itself, it must remain in the vine. Neither can you bear fruit unless you remain in me.” He went on to say, “As the Father has loved me, so I have loved you. Now remain in my love” (John 15:9). (Other translations of the Bible use the word “abide” instead of “remain.”)